

Open Research and Documentation: What, When, How?

Documenting as a Systemic Practice

Open Research in the Digital Humanities

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Why Documentation Matters

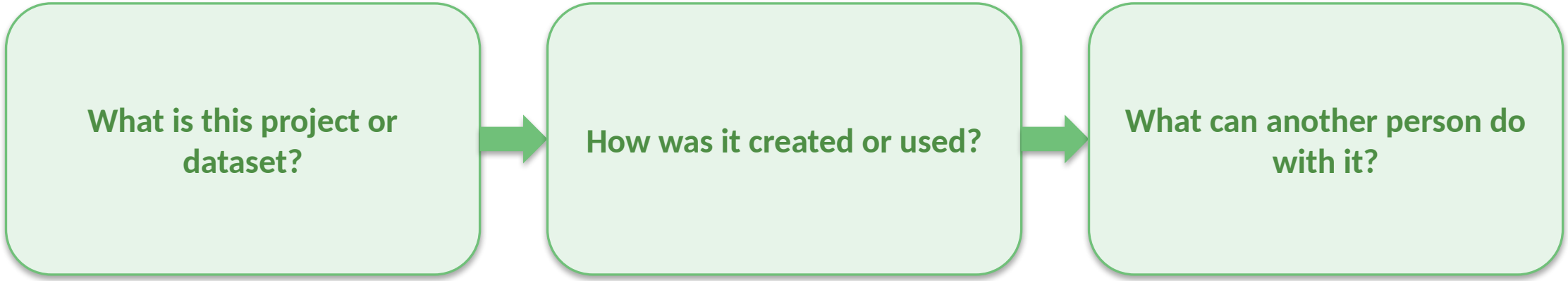
- Documentation is important for the long-term sustainability of Digital Humanities projects. As Edmond and Morselli explain, valuable work can be lost because of technical and resource-related challenges.
- A digital project may contain datasets, code, metadata, visualisations, written interpretation and an online interface — elements that depend on specific tools, platforms, people and decisions.
- If the relationships between the components are not documented, the project may become difficult to understand and reconstruct, even if some of its files remain available.
- Sustainability means preserving the final outputs, as well as documenting the knowledge and processes that make those outputs meaningful and reusable.

References for further reading:

Edmond, Jennifer, and Francesca Morselli. “Sustainability of Digital Humanities Projects as a Publication and Documentation Challenge.” Journal of Documentation 76, no. 5 (2020): 1019–31. https://doi.org/10.1108/JD-12-2019-0232.

Three Questions Documentation Should Answer

Documentation should help another person answer three questions:



These questions connect the identity of the research object with the process behind it and with its possible future uses.

Document as You Go

- Dunleavy and Monteath recommend documenting research as it unfolds, adding bits of information while accomplishing the stages of the research process.
- It is critically important to record the processes themselves and the decisions about coding, analysis and the direction of the research.
- Only thorough documentation can help researchers avoid problems later and prepare their work for publication and data deposit.

References for further reading:

Dunleavy, Patrick, and Timothy Monteath. Documenting Research as You Go. Zenodo, 2022. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.7670937.

What Should Be Documented?

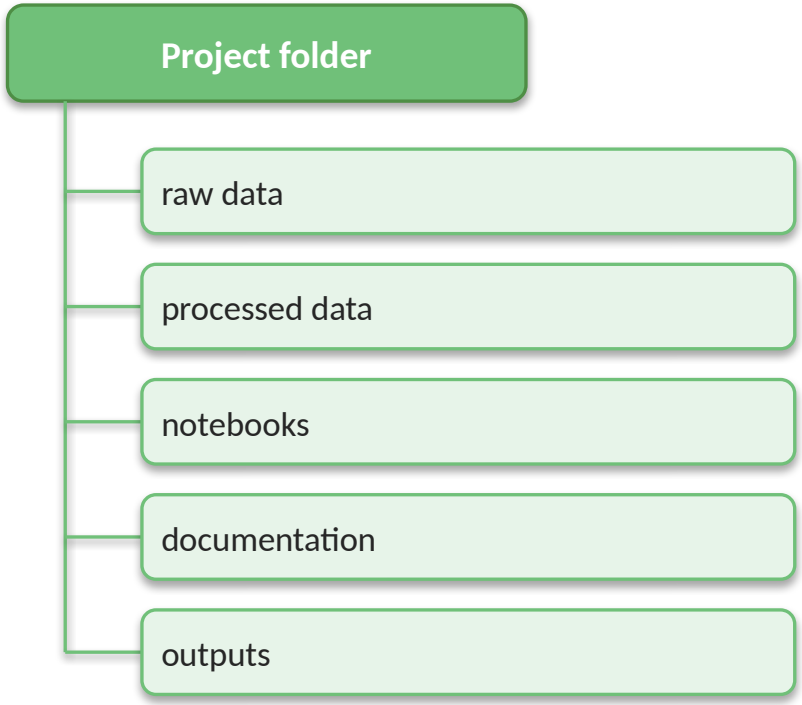
- **Research question & scope —** what you investigate and which part of the collection or dataset you use.
- **Source & provenance —** where the data came from, who created it, when you accessed it, the version, and any licences or restrictions.
- **The data itself —** what the records represent, what the main fields mean, and where information is incomplete or uncertain.
- **Methods, tools & environment —** software, notebooks, scripts, libraries or services, with important settings and versions.
- **Workflow —** the sequence of steps that transformed the original material into the final result.
- **Research decisions —** the interpretive choices: selection, handling incompleteness, visualisation choices and assumptions.
- Results, limitations & possible uses.

Building a Documentation Package

A clear documentation system may include:

- a README file
- a dataset description
- a workflow diagram
- a decision log
- a version log
- a record of data transformations
- instructions for using the code or notebooks
- information about licences and access conditions

Use separate folders, for example:



The exact structure can vary, but it should be understandable to someone who did not create it.

Documentation need not be perfect at first — the aim is the habit of making your research process transparent.

References for further reading:

Edmond, Jennifer, and Francesca Morselli. “Sustainability of Digital Humanities Projects as a Publication and Documentation Challenge.” Journal of Documentation 76, no. 5 (2020): 1019–31. https://doi.org/10.1108/JD-12-2019-0232.

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Dunleavy, Patrick, and Timothy Monteath. Documenting Research as You Go. Zenodo, 2022. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.7670937.